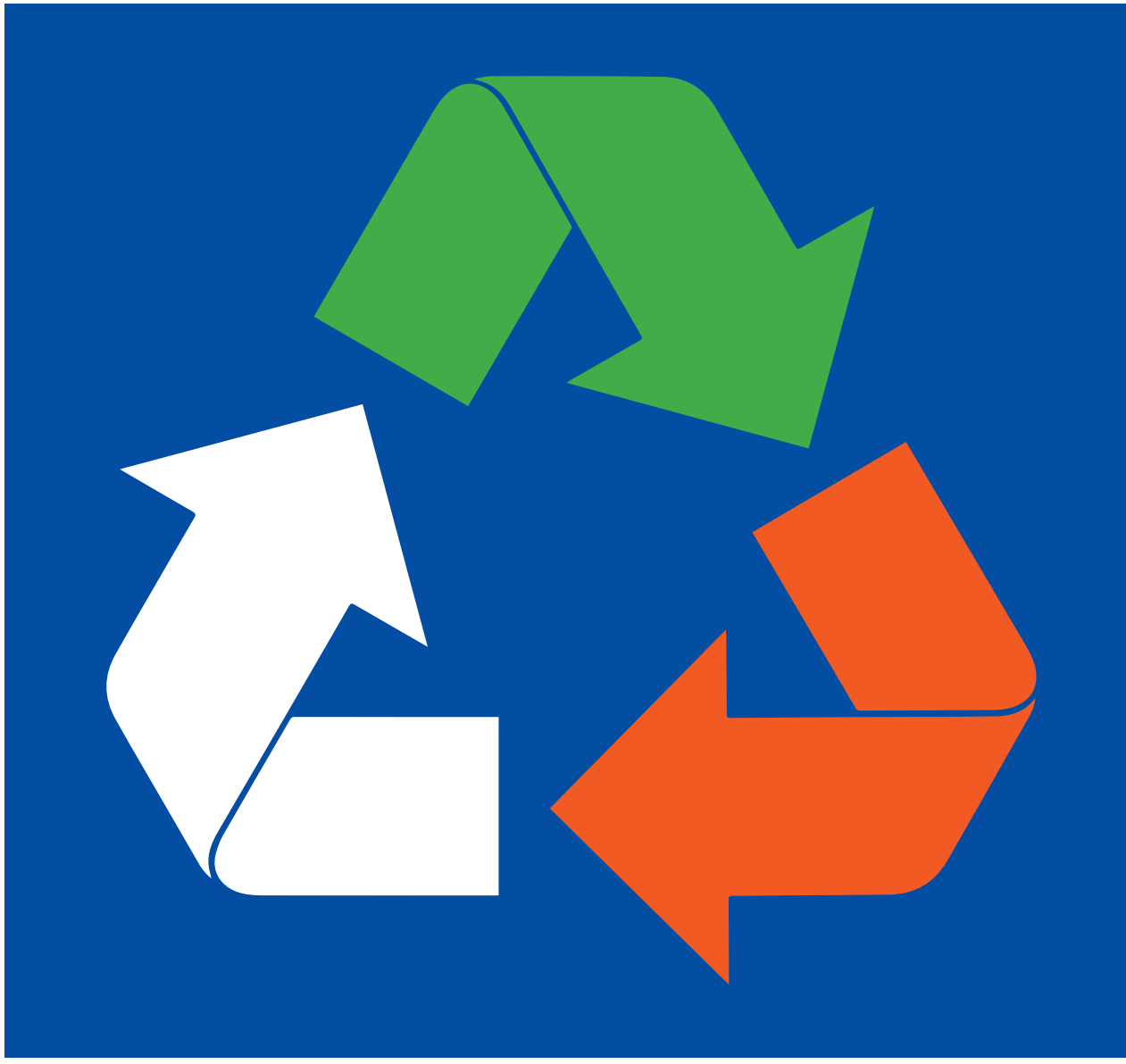


Illustration by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

IN THE NEW CONTROVERSY, THE KEY QUESTION IS: **WHAT ARE WE RECLAIMING TO THROW OUT THE OTHER?** INDIA WAS NOT A NAME GIVEN TO US BY THE BRITISH

the Achaemenid king Darius; and for the Arabs (after the eighth century), those who lived beyond the Indus were Al-Hind.

It would appear, therefore, that the name India or its variants, all derived from the river Indus or Sindhu, (and Sindhu is a Sanskrit word from the Vedas), originated far before British rule. However, the name Bharat is also both established and ancient, and objective historians are willing to accept this reality. Upinder writes: 'One of several explanations of the name Bharatvarsha connects it with the Bharata people, descendants of the legendary king Bharata, son of Dushyant and Shakuntala. Cosmography blends with geography in the Puranas, which were committed to writing around 300 CE. Bharatvarsha is said to consist of nine divisions (*khandas*), separated from one another by seas. But the mention of its mountains, rivers and places—some of which can be identified—suggests that the composers of such texts were familiar with various areas of the subcontinent, *and perceived them as part of a larger cultural whole*' (emphasis mine).

Bharata is also mentioned in the Mahabharata (circa 5th century BCE),